others, but I went into it not having a clue what to expect. About half an hour in, I scored my first senior goal for United. The ball rolled out to me, in front of the Stretford End, and I remember thinking: if I catch this right, something could happen. Even though I didn't really connect properly, the ball bobbled in somehow and I turned and ran away to celebrate. Eric Cantona was the first player to get to me. I was buzzing that much, he was having to fight me off in the end. I just wouldn't let go of him. *I've scored a goal and I'm celebrating with Eric Cantona*.

I really enjoyed myself. I think Galatasaray had left out some senior players, too, and the game wasn't as difficult as it might have been. We played well, and the fact that there were so many of the younger boys in the team made it even better. Starting the game had made a difference, too. I felt a lot more at home at Old Trafford that night than I had during my seventeen minutes down at Brighton, two years before. For us boys, it felt like the European Cup Final, never mind that United were eliminated whatever the result. As it was, we won 4–0, which is a decent score in a European game whatever the circumstances. The manager didn't say anything afterwards. He was disappointed to be out of Europe, but seemed happy enough with how the young lads had played.

That first start in a big European fixture was an exception for me. I still had work– and filling out—to do. The thing that has kept United and the players at the club driving on is the knowledge that if your standards slip, there's someone waiting to take your place. As a teenager, the doubts about whether you'd still be there in a week, a month, or even a year's time, were even more intense. It was back to the reserves after my start in the Galatasaray game. Back to wondering whether I was good enough to take the next big step: establishing myself in the first team by getting games in the Premier League. Sometimes in a career, even if you think you know what you need next, you have to be ready to make the best of what comes along.

It wasn't every day I got called in after training to see the manager in his office:

'Preston North End have asked if they could take you on loan for a month. I think it's a good idea.'

Straight away, I put two and two together and made five. I was nineteen. Nicky Butt and Gary Neville were already getting games on a fairly regular basis. I'd been involved with the first team, but I wasn't progressing as quickly as them. Had United decided I wasn't going to be strong enough to